

MATCHMANCER

Solo Dev Production Plan

Dual-Track: Unity Learning + AI Art Pipeline

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Art Style: Dark Fantasy | Engine: Unity (C#) | Tools: Midjourney / DALL-E 3 / Leonardo AI

1. Your Situation & Strategy

You're a total beginner with zero game dev experience, but you have a clean GDD, strong art direction instincts (from Soulstream), and access to AI image generation tools. This plan turns those assets into a playable match-3 game.

The strategy is simple: learn Unity and C# fundamentals while simultaneously building your art asset library with AI tools. By the time you can code the game, your art is ready to drop in.

Engine: Unity (free Personal license) with C#

AI Art Tools: Midjourney, DALL-E 3, Leonardo AI

Target: Playable MVP in 8–12 weeks (realistic for a learning solo dev)

Art Style: Dark fantasy with glowing sigils, crimson/teal energy, readable at phone scale

Phase	Track A: Learn Unity	Track B: AI Art
Weeks 1–2	Unity basics + C# fundamentals	6 tile icons + color palette
Weeks 3–4	Match-3 template + customization	3 character portraits + 3 specials
Weeks 5–6	Blockers + character ultimates	3 blockers + UI backgrounds
Weeks 7–8	25 levels + map screen + polish	Map screen + boosters + VFX sprites

2. Week-by-Week Breakdown

Each week has both tracks running in parallel. Spend mornings on Unity, evenings on art generation (or vice versa). The key is switching between them so neither feels like a grind.

Week 1: Foundation

Day	Track A: Unity	What To Do	Track B: Art
Day 1	Install Unity Hub + Unity 2022 LTS	Download from unity.com. Choose 2D template when creating first project. Follow the setup wizard.	Set up Midjourney/Leo accounts
Day 2	Unity Roll-a-Ball tutorial	Official Unity Learn tutorial. Teaches scenes, GameObjects, components, inspector. Do NOT skip.	Generate color palette test images
Day 3	Continue Roll-a-Ball	Finish the tutorial. Experiment: change speeds, colors, add extra objects. Break things on purpose.	Port Rune tile (3 variations)
Day 4	C# basics: variables, if/else	Unity Learn C# for beginners series (free). Focus on: int, float, string, bool, if statements.	OZONE Mark tile (3 variations)
Day 5	C# basics: loops, arrays	Continue C# series. Understand for loops and arrays — match-3 grids are literally 2D arrays.	Coven Seal tile (3 variations)
Day 6-7	C# basics: functions, classes	Finish C# fundamentals. Write a tiny script that spawns colored squares in a grid. Your first real step.	Remaining 3 tiles + review all 6

Week 2: Grid Prototype

Day	Track A: Unity	What To Do	Track B: Art
Day 1	Create 9x9 grid with code	Write a script that instantiates a 9x9 grid of colored squares. Just cubes or sprites, no matching yet.	Refine best tile variations
Day 2	Tile selection + swap logic	Detect tap/click on tiles. Swap two adjacent tiles. No match detection yet, just swap positions.	Generate Special tile icons (Line Sigil)
Day 3	Match-3 detection	Write CheckForMatches(): scan rows and columns for 3+ same-color tiles. Mark them.	Star Sigil + Nova Sigil icons
Day 4	Tile destruction + gravity	Destroy matched tiles. Make tiles above fall down. Spawn new tiles at top.	Blue character portrait (main)
Day 5	Cascade detection	After gravity fills gaps, check for new matches. Repeat until no more matches. This is the core loop!	Blue character (2 more angles)

Day 6-7	Polish: animations, score	Add simple scale/fade animations on match. Add a score counter. Playtest obsessively.	Crux character portrait (main)
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Week 3: Specials + Template Study

Day	Track A: Unity	What To Do	Track B: Art
Day 1	Match-4 = Line Sigil logic	When 4 tiles match, spawn a Line Sigil instead of destroying. Line Sigil clears row or column when matched.	Crux character (additional views)
Day 2	Match-5 = Star Sigil logic	Star Sigil clears all tiles of one chosen type. Add the choose-a-color popup.	Kaery character portrait (main)
Day 3	L/T shape = Nova Sigil	Detect L and T match shapes. Nova Sigil creates a 3x3 explosion when matched.	Kaery character (additional views)
Day 4-5	Buy + study a match-3 template	Unity Asset Store: buy a well-rated match-3 kit. Study how they handle: board generation, animation, UI, level loading.	Glass blocker overlay (1-2 layers)
Day 6-7	Compare your code to template	See what they did better. Adopt their patterns for things like level data, objective tracking, move counting.	Chain blocker + Stone/Armor blocker

Week 4: Blockers + Characters

Day	Track A: Unity	What To Do	Track B: Art
Day 1-2	Implement Glass blocker	Glass sits on tiles. Adjacent matches crack it (layer 1 then layer 2 = destroyed). Track layers per cell.	Character Ultimate button icons (x3)
Day 3	Implement Chain blocker	Chained tile can't be swapped until adjacent match removes the chain. One hit = freed.	UI background: dark fantasy board frame
Day 4	Implement Stone/Armor blocker	Stone takes 2-3 hits from adjacent matches. Track hit count. Visual should crack progressively.	Win screen + Lose screen backgrounds

Day 5-6	Character system: charge + ultimate	Add charge counter (+1 per match). At 10 charge, enable Ultimate button. Implement Blue's 4x4 clear.	Map screen node path background
Day 7	Implement Crux + Kaery ultimates	Crux: tap to clear row+column cross. Kaery: pick tile A, convert up to 8 into tile B.	Booster icons (Bomb, Line, Swap)

Week 5-6: Levels + UI

Day	Track A: Unity	What To Do	Track B: Art
Days 1-3	Level data system	Create a way to define levels: grid layout, which blockers, objective type, move limit. JSON or ScriptableObjects.	Polish all tile icons for final size
Days 4-6	Build levels 1-15	Follow the GDD ramp: 1-5 teach matching, 6-10 teach specials, 11-15 introduce Glass. Playtest each one.	VFX sprites: match particles, glow effects
Days 7-9	Build levels 16-25	16-20 add Chains, 21-25 mix all blockers. These should feel challenging but not impossible.	Character passive ability icons
Days 10-14	Map screen + character select	Node-based map (like Candy Crush). Character select before each level. Win/lose screens.	Final asset review + export at correct sizes

Week 7-8: Integration + Polish

Day	Track A: Unity	What To Do	Track B: Art
Days 1-3	Drop in final art assets	Replace all placeholder squares with your AI-generated tiles, character portraits, UI backgrounds.	Fix any art that doesn't read well in-game
Days 4-6	Sound + juice	Add match sounds, cascade sounds, ultimate activation sounds. Add screen shake, particle effects on big clears.	Generate any missing VFX/particle sprites
Days 7-10	Playtest loop	Play all 25 levels start to finish. Note where levels feel too easy/hard. Adjust move counts and blocker placement.	App icon + loading screen art

Days 11-14	Bug fixing + final build	Fix all bugs found in playtesting. Build for Android (APK) or iOS (TestFlight). Share with friends for feedback.	Store screenshots + promotional art
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3. AI Art Pipeline — Complete Prompt Library

Your reference image establishes the visual direction: dark fantasy, crimson/red energy, glowing runes, dramatic lighting, cracked stone environments. We extract these qualities but adapt them for match-3 tile readability.

3.1 Style DNA (Extracted from Reference)

Element	Matchmancer Application
Color Palette	Crimson red (#C41E3A), void black (#0A0A0A), molten gold (#FFD100), neon teal (#00D4FF), deep violet (#7B2CBF), pale silver (#C0C0C0)
Energy Style	Glowing sigils, crackling red/teal particle trails, runic circle ground effects, volumetric smoke
Materials	Cracked obsidian stone, oxidized dark metal, kintsugi gold cracks, leather with chain accents
Lighting	Dramatic chiaroscuro, red/crimson rim lighting, warm gold from rune glow, cool teal accents
Mood	Dark, powerful, supernatural — but stylized enough for mobile (not horror)

3.2 Tile Icon Prompts (6 Base Tiles)

CRITICAL RULE: Tiles must be simple, high-contrast icons readable at 60x60px on a phone screen. Generate at 512x512, test by scaling to 60x60. If you can't tell what it is at tiny size, simplify.

Platform: Use Leonardo AI (SDXL model, guidance 8, 50 steps) for icons. Clean backgrounds are easier to control.

1. Port Rune (Cyan/Teal #00D4FF)

Game icon, simple glowing cyan portal rune symbol, circular gate design with inner geometric pattern, neon teal glow (#00D4FF), floating in void, clean black background, flat icon style with subtle 3D depth, sharp edges, game UI

asset, no text, 512x512. Negative: detailed background, realistic, blurry, text, watermark

2. OZONE Mark (Electric Gold #FFD100)

Game icon, angular electric gold faction emblem, sharp geometric syndicate symbol with lightning motif, molten gold glow (#FFD100), metallic sheen, clean black background, flat icon style with subtle 3D depth, sharp edges, game UI asset, no text, 512x512. Negative: detailed background, realistic, blurry, text, watermark

3. Coven Seal (Deep Violet #7B2CBF)

Game icon, mystical purple witch coven seal, circular occult symbol with pentagram inner design, glowing violet energy (#7B2CBF), ethereal smoke wisps, clean black background, flat icon style with subtle 3D depth, sharp edges, game UI asset, no text, 512x512. Negative: detailed background, realistic, blurry, text, watermark

4. Witchbreed Thorn (Crimson Red #C41E3A)

Game icon, crimson red thorned mark symbol, sharp organic thorn pattern forming a diamond shape, glowing red energy (#C41E3A), blood-red particle effects, clean black background, flat icon style with subtle 3D depth, sharp edges, game UI asset, no text, 512x512. Negative: detailed background, realistic, blurry, text, watermark

5. Soulstream Shard (White/Silver #C0C0C0)

Game icon, luminous white crystal shard, faceted gemstone with inner light, silver-white glow (#C0C0C0) with prismatic highlights, floating energy particles, clean black background, flat icon style with subtle 3D depth, sharp edges, game UI asset, no text, 512x512. Negative: detailed background, realistic, blurry, text, watermark

6. Petsha Charm (Warm Amber #D4A017)

Game icon, warm golden charm coin, circular amulet with animal paw motif center, amber-gold glow (#D4A017), ancient metallic texture, subtle chain links, clean black background, flat icon style with subtle 3D depth, sharp edges, game UI asset, no text, 512x512. Negative: detailed background, realistic, blurry, text, watermark

3.3 Character Portrait Prompts (3 Characters)

Use Midjourney (--ar 2:3 --style raw --v 6.1) for character portraits. These appear as UI bust portraits during character select and level play. Style follows the reference: dramatic dark fantasy, strong physique, supernatural energy, but each character has their own color identity.

Blue — Soulstream Pulse Caster (Teal/Cyan energy identity)

Cinematic bust portrait of a young mystical warrior, sharp jawline, silver-white hair swept back, glowing teal-cyan eyes, wearing dark obsidian armor with cracked kintsugi gold veins, teal energy particles orbiting around shoulders, Soulstream crystal embedded in chest plate glowing white-blue, dark ruined temple background with volumetric teal mist, dramatic chiaroscuro lighting, rim light from cyan energy source, shot on 85mm f/1.8, dark fantasy game character art, hyper-detailed, 8K. Negative: cartoon, anime, bright colors, modern clothing, blurry, text --ar 2:3 --style raw --v 6.1

Crux — Port Cross Navigator (Gold/Amber energy identity)

Cinematic bust portrait of a tactical rogue navigator, angular features, dark hair with gold streaks, amber-gold glowing eyes, wearing weathered dark leather coat with oxidized bronze buckles and gold runic stitching, golden compass rose pendant glowing at chest, golden crosshair energy forming behind head, dark stormy sky with portal rifts background, warm gold rim lighting mixed with cool shadows, dramatic Renaissance-style hard shadow edges, shot on 85mm f/1.8, dark fantasy game character art, hyper-detailed, 8K. Negative: cartoon, anime, bright colors, modern clothing, blurry, text --ar 2:3 --style raw --v 6.1

Kaery — Glamour Shift Enchantress (Violet/Purple energy identity)

Cinematic bust portrait of an enigmatic enchantress, high cheekbones, dark hair with violet-purple streaks, glowing purple eyes with magical seal iris pattern, wearing deep crimson velvet cloak over dark armor with violet crystal fragments embedded in shoulder pieces, floating violet tarot cards orbiting near hands, purple transformation energy swirling, dark candlelit chamber background with occult symbols, warm amber candlelight mixed with violet magical glow, shot on 85mm f/1.8, dark fantasy game character art, hyper-detailed, 8K. Negative: cartoon, anime, bright colors, modern clothing, blurry, text --ar 2:3 --style raw --v 6.1

3.4 Special Tiles + Blocker Prompts

Line Sigil (Horizontal beam icon)

Game icon, glowing horizontal energy beam sigil, sleek arrow-like design, neon cyan and gold energy trail, motion blur streaks, clean black background, flat icon style with subtle 3D depth, game UI asset, no text, 512x512. Negative: detailed background, realistic, blurry, text

Star Sigil (Radiant star icon)

Game icon, radiant five-pointed star sigil, glowing white-gold core with prismatic rainbow edge highlights, celestial energy particles, clean black background, flat icon style with subtle 3D depth, game UI asset, no text, 512x512. Negative: detailed background, realistic, blurry, text

Nova Sigil (Explosion icon)

Game icon, explosive nova burst sigil, circular shockwave design with crimson-red and gold energy rings expanding outward, particle debris, clean black background, flat icon style with subtle 3D depth, game UI asset, no text, 512x512. Negative: detailed background, realistic, blurry, text

Glass Blocker (Layer 1) (Transparent ice overlay)

Game UI overlay, cracked glass texture, single crack pattern, translucent ice-blue tint, frost edges, transparent center, game asset overlay, PNG with transparency feel, 512x512. Negative: opaque, solid color, text

Glass Blocker (Layer 2) (Heavy crack overlay)

Game UI overlay, heavily cracked glass texture, spider-web crack pattern, translucent ice-blue tint, more frost, nearly breaking apart, game asset overlay, 512x512. Negative: opaque, solid color, text

Chain Blocker (Iron chain wrap)

Game icon, dark iron chains wrapped in X pattern over a tile space, oxidized metal texture, faint red glow between chain links, locked padlock at center, clean dark background, game UI asset, 512x512. Negative: realistic, detailed background, text

Stone/Armor Blocker (Cracked stone shield)

Game icon, dark stone armor shield tile, cracked obsidian surface with faint kintsugi gold veins, heavy and solid appearance, 3 hit marks visible as progressive cracks, clean dark background, game UI asset, 512x512. Negative: realistic, detailed background, text

4. Complete Asset Checklist

Track your progress. Every asset needed for the MVP:

Asset	Count	Size	Status
Base Tiles (6 types)	6	512x512	☐ TODO
Special Tiles (Line/Star/Nova)	3	512x512	☐ TODO
Glass Blocker (2 layers)	2	512x512	☐ TODO
Chain Blocker	1	512x512	☐ TODO
Stone/Armor Blocker (3 states)	3	512x512	☐ TODO
Character Portrait: Blue	1	1024x1536	☐ TODO
Character Portrait: Crux	1	1024x1536	☐ TODO

Character Portrait: Kaery	1	1024x1536	☐ TODO
Ultimate Button Icons (x3)	3	256x256	☐ TODO
Passive Ability Icons (x3)	3	128x128	☐ TODO
Booster Icons (Bomb/Line/Swap)	3	256x256	☐ TODO
Board Background	1	1080x1920	☐ TODO
Map Screen Background	1	1080x1920	☐ TODO
Win Screen Background	1	1080x1920	☐ TODO
Lose Screen Background	1	1080x1920	☐ TODO
Character Select Background	1	1080x1920	☐ TODO
App Icon	1	1024x1024	☐ TODO
Loading Screen	1	1080x1920	☐ TODO
Match VFX Particles (per color)	6	256x256	☐ TODO
Ultimate VFX (per character)	3	512x512	☐ TODO

TOTAL: ~42 unique assets for MVP launch.

5. Essential Resources & Links

5.1 Unity Learning Path (Free)

1. Unity Hub Download: unity.com/download
2. Roll-a-Ball Tutorial: learn.unity.com (search "Roll a Ball")
3. C# for Beginners: Unity Learn > Pathways > Junior Programmer
4. YouTube: "Zigurous Match 3 Unity Tutorial" (full free series)
5. YouTube: "Brackeys" channel (best beginner Unity tutorials)

5.2 Match-3 Specific

- Unity Asset Store: search "Match 3 Kit" or "Match 3 Starter" (budget \$30-80)
- Key concepts to Google: "Unity 2D grid system", "Unity ScriptableObject level data", "Unity match-3 cascade logic"

5.3 AI Art Tools

- Midjourney: Best for character portraits (use --ar 2:3 --style raw --v 6.1)
- Leonardo AI: Best for icons/tiles (SDXL model, guidance 7-9, 50 steps, use negative prompt box)
- DALL-E 3: Best for UI backgrounds and scenes (natural language prompts, strong composition)

5.4 Art Pipeline Rules

6. Generate 4 variations per prompt. Pick the best one.
7. Change only ONE variable per iteration (lighting OR pose OR material, never all three).
8. Test every tile at 60x60px. If it's not readable, simplify the prompt.
9. Remove backgrounds in Photopea (free) or remove.bg before importing to Unity.
10. Export all game assets as PNG with transparent backgrounds.

6. Solo Dev Survival Rules

These aren't motivational fluff. They're hard-earned rules from people who actually shipped games solo:

Rule 1: Ugly prototype first. Your game will look terrible for weeks. That's correct. Gameplay feel matters more than visuals at the start. The art comes later and transforms everything overnight.

Rule 2: Playtest every single day. Even if you only added one feature, play the game. Feel what's fun and what's broken. Your hands will tell you what your eyes miss.

Rule 3: One feature at a time. Never work on blockers and characters and UI simultaneously. Finish one, commit, move on. Context-switching is the solo dev killer.

Rule 4: The GDD is your anchor. When you feel lost or tempted to add features, re-read the GDD. It says "Ignore for now" on relics, events, story, PvP. Trust that. Build the MVP.

Rule 5: Ship ugly, then polish. A working ugly game beats a beautiful broken one. Get all 25 levels playable first. Then make them pretty.

Rule 6: Track B keeps you sane. When coding frustrates you, switch to art generation. When prompts frustrate you, switch to code. Two tracks = no burnout dead ends.